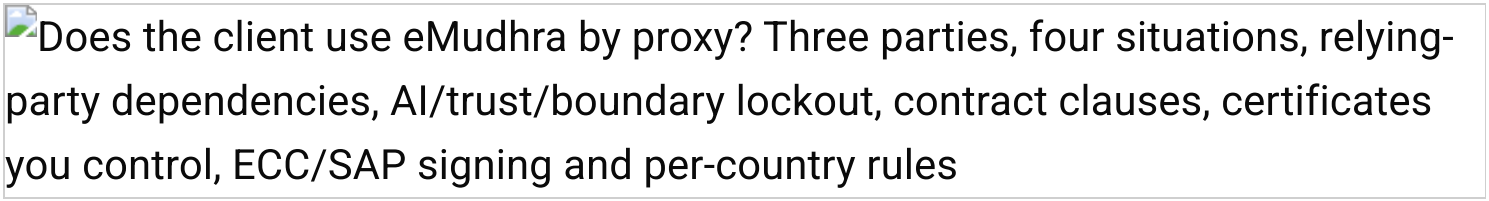
SECURITY AND TRUST

Signing Keys by Proxy

AI security, globalization, tools and permissions. **Whose key signs, who granted it, and what stops when a chain is distrusted.**

Every signature answers two questions: *who issued the key*, and *who granted the signer the right to use it*. When a consultancy, a plugin or a platform signs on your behalf with a certificate authority (CA) you never chose, you inherit that CA by proxy: its trust, its revocation service, its jurisdiction, and its failures. October 2026 showed what that costs when the CA is distrusted. This article sets out when you use a CA by proxy, what locks out when its chain breaks, how ECC/SAP signing fits, what each market requires, and how to build a Globalization MVP security first, with a cutover checklist to get there.



1. When you use a CA by proxy

Three parties are involved: the **client** (you), the **consultancy** or vendor, and the **CA** that issued the consultancy's certificate. Whether you use that CA depends on whose certificate signs and who runs the system.

SITUATION	DO YOU USE THE CA?	WHY
The consultancy signs its own documents (SOW, invoice, sign-off)	**No**	You are a relying party: you validate the chain and revocation. No account, key or contract with the CA
Your people sign through the consultancy's setup (its Acrobat Sign account or eSign portal)	**Yes, indirectly**	Your signers' identity data goes to the CA: effectively a subprocessor you never chose
The consultancy builds or runs your systems and installs the CA's certificates in your AEM, Acrobat Sign or SAP	**Yes, directly**	It is now your configuration; the consultancy only made the choice
You sign with your own CA and only receive the consultancy's signed documents	**No**	You need to trust the CA's root, usually through Adobe's trust list (AATL) or the OS store

Even as a relying party only, you depend on the CA for **revocation checks** (its OCSP responder or CRL; long-term validation helps only if it was embedded at signing), **trust in its root**, and the **legal weight** of the signature in your jurisdiction.

These are patterns, not claims about any firm. A contract, or the certificate chain of a signed PDF, shows which provider a given consultancy uses.

2. Why it is not hypothetical: October 2026

A key ceremony at eMudhra on 30 April 2025 generated eight intermediate CA keys with too little randomness. Between 17 and 20 October 2026 a researcher recovered all eight private keys from the public certificates, and Chrome, Mozilla, Apple and Microsoft blocked them: six TLS intermediates and two code-signing intermediates. Chrome removes the emSign ECC Root CA - G3 from devices from 27 October. Go, NSS, Ubuntu, Debian and Composer shipped trust-store fixes on 20 October, and the Node.js releases of 21 October also

reject the chains. India's Digital Signature Certificates run under India's own CA licensing rather than the browser root programs and, as reported, were not directly affected.

The keys were not stolen; they were computable. An audited process with certified hardware still produced weak keys, so the lesson is about provenance: know which of your certificates chain through which CA, and sign your own records with keys you own and can retire. Background: Hydrogen or bespoke stack, Org Trust Layer, and reporting by The Hacker News and Help Net Security.

3. AI security: trust and boundary lockout

A distrusted chain is not a warning. Browsers and runtimes refuse the connection, and everything that depended on it stops.

LOCKOUT	WHAT STOPS	SIGNAL
AI lockout	Agents, AI gateways and MCP tools calling an API whose certificate chains through a blocked intermediate fail the TLS handshake, so the tool call never happens. Mandates signed with keys from an exposed environment must be rejected; code-signed packages and adapters fail verification	Denied tool calls, handshake errors in agent logs
Trust lockout	Browsers, operating systems, Node, Composer and Python's `certifi` refuse the chain: the site or API is unreachable. Signed documents on the chain show as invalid wherever they are opened	Unreachable origins, invalid signature banners
Boundary lockout	Every crossing (edge to origin, webhooks, feed syncs, partner APIs) is a TLS handshake. Feeds stall and webhooks fail. Consent, opt-out and deletion events stop propagating: a **DSR lockout**	Stalled feeds, growing webhook retries, unacknowledged deletions

Recover faster: keep an inventory of which certificates chain through which CA, automate reissue (ACME) with a second CA ready, queue DSR events so they

can be replayed with their timestamps, and sign records with keys you own so they still verify when a public CA does not.

4. Tools and permissions: a certificate is not a grant

A CA proves who holds a certificate. It does not prove what they may sign or do. That needs a **grant** from the organization: who, what, for how long, revoked on exit. For AI agents the grant is a **mandate**: scoped to tools and markets, expiring, and checked on every action.

Certificates you control

	CRM-SYNC CERTIFICATE LINK	XANO SELF-HOST CERTIFICATE
What it is	Licence grants, upload attestations and deletion records signed with crm-sync's Ed25519 key, published at `/.well-known/jwks.json`	Self-hosted Xano on infrastructure you operate, with a TLS certificate from a CA you choose
How it is checked	`crm-sync.dev/license/verify`: anyone verifies offline, with no account and no CA chain that can be distrusted; short links at `/v/<hash>`, print QR at `/license/qr/<hash>.svg`	Your trust store: confirm the Node and Composer bundles reject the October 2026 eMudhra chains
Key custody	The platform's signing key; the public half is published	Your own HSM or key vault, in country

Assets that prove provenance (PDFs and firmware, images, 3D files, docs) are vaulted the same way: each file under its own key, every upload certified, every download granted and recorded in a hash-chained ledger. See the Protected Firmware Asset Management and Download Service and Firmware asset publishing.

ECC/SAP signing: the same scrutiny, plus two ECC-specific risks

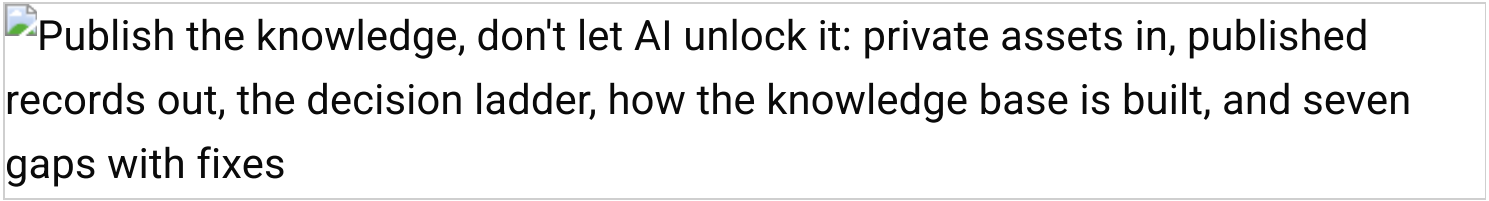
WHAT GETS SIGNED	MECHANISM IN ECC	WHO USUALLY SETS IT UP	PROXY RISK
PDF forms (invoices, POs, delivery notes)	Interactive Forms by Adobe through Adobe Document Services (ADS), with a `.pfx` credential	Consultants, during the build	Directly: the CA behind that credential is now yours
Approvals and records (QM, batch records, change master, 21 CFR Part 11)	SAP digital signature through SSF, keys in PSE files managed in `STRUST`	Basis team or consultants	Directly, if they imported keys or certificates from their CA
Outbound HTTPS (Shopify, Google, banks, tax portals)	ICM web server, SSL client PSEs in `STRUST`	Basis team or consultants	Trust store: ECC may still trust a chain everything around it now refuses
India statutory filings (GST, e-invoice, company filings)	Digital Signature Certificates on USB tokens	Often the consultancy or an outside CA firm	Grant problem: the certificate names a consultant, not the client
Spreadsheets (migration templates, LSMW, Migration Cockpit, reports)	Usually unsigned; sometimes Office signatures with a personal certificate	Consultants	No signature at all, so no provenance

- `STRUST` **doesn't update itself.** Browsers and runtimes shipped the distrust in October; an ABAP trust store changes only when someone edits it. Check every PSE in `STRUST`, plus ADS and Java stack keystores.
- **The S/4HANA move carries trust.** A system conversion (SUM with DMO) migrates the PSEs too. Clean out stale or proxy certificates first; ECC mainstream maintenance ends in 2027.
- **Unsigned spreadsheets are the weakest link.** Hash each handoff file and record it, signed with a key you own.

5. Knowledge base: publish, don't unlock

Chatbots that answer from locked PDFs, docs, Markdown and spreadsheets, or from raw images and 3D files (JPG, PNG, SVG, WebP, OBJ, STL, FBX, GLB), read sources nobody approved, signed or versioned. A knowledge base for AI is **published once** as structured records carrying issuer, version, market, locale and consent scope, hashed and signed with a key you own. Media and 3D files become a manifest (alt text, dimensions, product link, licence) while the file stays in the vault under its own key.

The chatbot then climbs a decision ladder on that evidence: retrieval (RAG), corrective retrieval when evidence is weak (CRAG), a locale or personalisation adapter (LoRA) only where consent allows, and a hand-off to a person when the answer carries money, law or risk. No rung opens a locked file, no agent acts without a mandate, and price and stock come live from the system of record, never from embeddings. More in The AI ladder.



Chatbot plugins: what they can't include

Shopify app-store chat plugins and enterprise suites such as Sprinklr run the bot as a third-party script with the vendor's own storage, keys and certificates. That makes them a signing-keys-by-proxy problem of their own: whatever the shopper types lands in the vendor's transcripts, in the vendor's region, under the vendor's CA. Three things should stay out of them.

WHAT	TYPICAL CHAT PLUGIN OR SPRINKLR BOT	PUBLISHED-KB CHATBOT
Card data (PCI)	Must not be typed into chat: a transcript holding card numbers puts the vendor, and you, in PCI DSS scope, and masking depends on the vendor	Never accepted. Payment happens only in Shopify checkout
Personal data (PII) such as address, email, phone or ID numbers	Kept in the vendor's transcripts and region, outside your consent ledger, and missed when a deletion request runs	Not collected in chat. Identity comes from the signed-in account; consent is attached and deletion propagates
Checkout links	A generic product or cart link, without the shopper's market, consent state or grant	A URL hand-off to Shopify checkout with market and consent resolved; payment never in chat
Knowledge source	The vendor's copy of your help content, or private files uploaded to it	Published, signed records; Sprinklr content is migrated into them, then retired as a live source
Keys and certificates	The vendor's CA and keys, inherited by proxy	Keys you own, verifiable offline

Check each vendor's terms and data-processing addendum for where transcripts are stored and how card numbers are masked; the point is that none of those choices are yours.

Chatbot build requirements

A headless Shopify proof of concept, built on public product feeds and chatbot articles, shows the gap this section describes. It uses public data on purpose, to show the difference between being visible and being governed. Anything public can be viewed by AI, but that does not incorporate it into a knowledge base corpus with rules and permissions: no issuer, version, locale or consent scope, and no grant saying who may use it for what. Public articles an AI can read are still ungoverned until they are published as records.

Why an ungoverned ladder hallucinates. A chatbot or AI escalation ladder that retrieves from public docs without a governed corpus pulls *anything* that matches: an old article, another market's price, a machine translation, a page written for a different audience. With no guardrails, no global ISO rules and no personalised consent state, it has nothing to check an answer against, so it fills the gaps:

MISSING	WHAT THE LADDER DOES WITHOUT IT	GOVERNED CORPUS
Guardrails	Answers from any matching page, including retired or off-topic ones, and blends them	Retrieval reads published records only; weak evidence goes to CRAG or a person, never a guess
Global ISO rules	Mixes countries, languages, currencies and dates: a US price in a Korean answer, a stale date shown as current	Every record keyed by ISO 3166 country, BCP 47 language, ISO 4217 currency and ISO 8601 UTC time; retrieval filters on them
Personalised consent state	Personalises for everyone, or for no one, and can't tell which	Each answer checks the shopper's consent at the moment it's given; the locale adapter by default, personalisation only with consent
Provenance	Cites nothing, or cites a page that says something else	Each answer names its record, its issuer and its grant

- ☐ **Migrate** each Sprinklr article into a canonical record (one answer per question), then stop reading Sprinklr live
- ☐ **Publish** every record with issuer, version, market, locale and consent scope, hashed and signed with a key you own
- ☐ **Re-index** retrieval from the published records only, filtered by locale
- ☐ **Hand off** checkout by URL to Shopify; take no card data and no personal data in chat
- ☐ **Trace** every answer to its record, its issuer and its grant
- ☐ **Retire** Sprinklr as a source once the published set covers its questions

LoRA audience training, linked to BigQuery and organic lookup

Two things are easy to confuse. **Audiences** decide *who* gets a personalised answer; **LoRA adapters** decide *how* the model writes for them: tone, vocabulary, format. BigQuery holds the audience, organic lookup supplies the evidence of how each market actually asks, and the adapter is trained only on de-identified pairs with a training basis. Personal data never goes into model weights, because an erasure request can't reach inside a trained model.

```
BigQuery (consent-filtered, keyed by ISO country, language, currency, UTC time)
  ├─ audiences ─────→ GA4 export + Shopify orders → segments, pLTV (BigQuery ML)
  │                   → cohort labels, held below a minimum cohort size
  ├─ organic lookup ─→ Search Console bulk export: queries by country, language, device (aggreg
  │                   → KB gaps: questions searched but not answered → publish records
  │                   → evaluation set: real phrasing per market
  └─ training pairs ─→ redacted, de-identified question-and-answer pairs + cohort label
                      with training consent → clean room → LoRA adapter per market × cohort
                      → registry: dataset_hash, record_count, consent basis, retire_by
Chatbot: pickAdapter(locale, cohort, consent) → base model + adapter; facts from published recc
```

SOURCE IN BIGQUERY	USED FOR	NEVER USED FOR
GA4 export, with Consent Mode states	Cohort membership counts; which questions lead to conversion	Individual training rows
Shopify orders and pLTV scores	Cohort labels, under a pseudonymous ID	Weights that contain a person
Search Console bulk export (organic queries)	Knowledge base gaps; evaluation phrasing and vocabulary per market	Targeting a person: the data is aggregated by query
Redacted helpdesk question-and-answer pairs	Training pairs for tone and format	Facts: those stay in published records, so erasure still works

Rules that keep it governed:

- **Training consent is its own scope.** Marketing or personalisation consent is not consent to train; only records with a training basis enter the clean room.
- **Minimum cohort.** A cohort below the threshold gets no adapter and no label; it falls back to the locale adapter.
- **In-country training.** Korean data trains only on Korean-hosted systems; each market's rule from section 6 applies to training as well as storage.
- **Retire and retrain.** Every adapter carries `retire_by`; a withdrawal is honoured by retraining without the withdrawn records, not by editing weights.
- **Organic lookup feeds the corpus first.** A question people search for that the knowledge base can't answer becomes a published record before it becomes training data, so the adapter changes how the answer is written, never what it says.

Background: Google audiences and conversions with Vertex AI, and where LoRA fits and the clean room.

6. Globalization: rules management by market

Each market sets whether data must stay in country, on what basis it may leave, and which Cloudflare and Xano options keep it where it belongs.

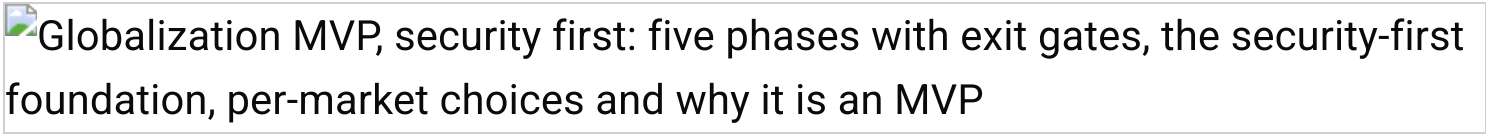
MARKET	LAW	DATA IN COUNTRY	CROSS-BORDER TRANSFER	CLOUDFLARE	XANO
China	PIPL, Data Security Law, Cybersecurity Law	Required for critical infrastructure operators and above volume thresholds; important data stays	Security assessment, standard contract or certification, unless an exemption applies	China Network via JD Cloud (Enterprise), needs an ICP filing; Geo Key Manager picks key regions	No mainland region: self-host on a mainland cloud, with its own TLS certificate from a CA you choose
Japan	APPI	Not required by law	Consent naming the country, or a recipient with equivalent safeguards; EU adequacy	Regional Services and Geo Key Manager keep TLS processing and keys in Japan	A Japan-region instance where offered, or self-host in Japan
Korea	PIPA (2023 amendment)	No general rule; sector rules for finance and public-sector cloud	Consent before transfer, or a certified or adequate recipient; disclose country and recipient	Regional Services and Geo Key Manager; check the Korea region	A Seoul-region instance, or self-host in Korea
Vietnam	Personal Data Protection Law (from 2026), Decree 53	Some services must store in Vietnam; foreign firms when ordered by the regulator	Transfer impact assessment filed with the Ministry of Public Security	No local residency product; keep personal data out of edge logs and caches	Self-host in Vietnam where localisation applies; otherwise a nearby region with the filing
Singapore	PDPA	Not required by law	Comparable protection: contract, binding corporate rules or certification	Regional Services and Geo Key Manager; check the region list	A Singapore-region instance where offered

MARKET	LAW	DATA IN COUNTRY	CROSS-BORDER TRANSFER	CLOUDFLARE	XANO
Taiwan	PDPA (2023 amendment)	Not general; sector rules	Allowed unless the regulator restricts a destination, e.g. mainland China for some sectors	Standard network; keep keys out of restricted regions	Nearest region or self-host; never route through a restricted destination
EU / Germany	GDPR, BDSG, TDDDG	Not required by law; often a contract term for public sector and health	Adequacy (including EU-US DPF, Japan, Korea, UK) or SCCs with a transfer assessment	Data Localization Suite: Regional Services, Customer Metadata Boundary, Geo Key Manager (EU)	An EU-region instance, or self-host in Germany
UK	UK GDPR, DPA 2018, Data (Use and Access) Act 2025	Not required by law	UK adequacy regulations, IDTA or Addendum; UK-US data bridge	Regional Services; check the UK region	A UK or EU-region instance, or self-host in the UK

Rules are summarised, not legal advice. Check Cloudflare's and Xano's current region lists for your plan; the AI cross-border requirements checklist goes deeper on transfer bases.

7. Globalization MVP, security first

Build the trust layer before the first market, so every market after it is a variable and a region, not a new integration.



PHASE	BUILD	EXIT GATE
0 · Trust foundation	Own root CA created offline; issuing CA in your Cloudflare account; key set (JWKS) published; hash-chained ledger in Xano	Every signature verifies against your key
1 · Boundary	mTLS per service and agent; consent checked at the edge; egress gate (no consent, no send); a trust store you own and update	Nothing crosses without a certificate and consent
2 · First market	Home market live end to end; knowledge base published as signed records; locale-filtered retrieval; live price from the system of record	One market, every answer traceable
3 · Add markets	A new market is one build variable; residency per market (region or self-host) chosen up front; transfer basis on file	Each market's data in its region, with evidence
4 · AI rungs	RAG, then CRAG on weak evidence; LoRA with the locale adapter by default, and audience adapters trained from BigQuery cohorts and organic lookup only with training consent; mandates for every agent action	No rung opens a locked file; no adapter holds personal data

Phases 0 and 1 ship before any market. Every later phase inherits the keys, grants, consent gate and ledger, which is what keeps it an MVP rather than a rebuild per market.

8. AI cutover checklist

Move AI onto keys you own and grants you can revoke, without a lockout: inventory first, switch in a window, then retire what no one granted.



Before cutover: inventory

- ☐ **Inventory every certificate**, with its issuer chain: TLS, `STRUST`, ADS, Java keystores, CI runners
- ☐ **List every signing key** and who holds it: staff, consultants, DSC tokens

- [ ] **Publish your own key set** (JWKS) for the records you sign, so they verify offline
- [ ] **Write the grants**: who may sign or act on what, for how long
- [ ] **Publish the knowledge base** as signed records with content hashes; no locked files
- [ ] **Map each market's rule**: residency, transfer basis, Cloudflare and Xano region
- [ ] **Make DSR events replayable**: queue consent, opt-out and deletion with timestamps

Cutover window: switch

- [ ] **Agents act only under mandates**: scoped, expiring grants per tool and per market
- [ ] **mTLS per service and agent**: a client certificate each, revocable one at a time
- [ ] **Retrieval reads published records** only, locale-filtered; never private buckets
- [ ] **Price and stock stay live** from the system of record, never embeddings
- [ ] **Keep the old path read-only**: switch traffic, don't delete; roll back by route
- [ ] **Watch the lockout signals**: handshake failures, denied tool calls, stalled feeds

After cutover: retire

- [ ] **Revoke what no one granted**: consultant and proxy certificates, old API keys
- [ ] **Retire old keys** and republish the key set; old records still verify
- [ ] **Replay the DSR queue** and log a receipt from every system that acted
- [ ] **Prove residency**: each market's data in its region, with evidence

☐ **Embed LTV** in signed documents, so revocation info and timestamps travel with them

☐ **Schedule trust-store reviews**: browsers patch themselves; `STRUST` and runtimes don't

Contract clauses to ask for

- **Disclose every provider**: every trust service provider and CA used for your signers or systems.
- **Certificates issued to the client**: certificates installed in your systems name you, not the consultancy.
- **Embed LTV**: revocation info and timestamps embedded, so documents stay verifiable after the relationship ends.

The cutover is done when every key has an issuer you chose, every action has a grant you can revoke, and every market's data has a region you can prove.

Related

- Org Trust Layer: your own CA, fewer plugins
- The AI ladder: retrieval, adapters, humans, and who holds the keys
- Entitlement security
- Hydrogen or bespoke stack
- AI cross-border requirements checklist

Patterns, not claims about any firm. eMudhra incident details per The Hacker News and Help Net Security, October 2026. Country rules summarised; not legal advice.